



are no Amish in Europe, and over 80 percent still live where their ancestors settled, in the states of Pennsylvania, Indiana, and Ohio. The order was named after one of their early leaders, Jacob Amman, who laid down their

defining principles: living apart from the world, remaining close to the land, supporting one another, and shunning any form of adornment. This last rule has led the Amish to be known as “the plain people.”

HOME LIFE

Families are usually large and closely knit. Discipline is strong, but Amish parents recognize and allow a limited period of adolescent rebellion. The term they use for this—*rumm-shpringa* (meaning running around)—is the equivalent of “sowing wild oats.”



NIMBLE FINGERS

Apart from things like underwear and men's suits, which tend to be bought from specialty stores, an Amish family's clothing is made by the women. The sewing machines they use are powered by treadle rather than electricity. The Amish are also known for their patchwork and quilting skills, and their quilts are widely sold to bring in extra money.

Young girls learn how to sew from their mothers.



LEARNING BY EXPERIENCE

Children go to Amish schools until they're about 13. After that, they gain the skills they need through on-the-job training: boys are apprenticed on a farm or in a workshop; girls work at home.

Amish clothing is plain and dark. Single women wear nothing on their heads (except to church); married ladies wear white caps.

